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# He Became America's Most Entitled, Ridiculed Actor. He's Found a Brilliant Way to Come Back.

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# He Became America's Most Entitled, Ridiculed Actor. He's Found a Brilliant Way to Come Back.

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As a New Yorker who's watching Knicks fever descend across the city, I would never try to claim the sacred mantle of the long-suffering Knicks fan. I don't follow sports, and I haven't watched a single basketball game this year. But I am, in my own way, a fan of the team, because I'm a big fan of celebrities being fans of the Knicks. I love to see pictures and clips of them courtside decked out in blue and orange at Madison Square Garden, and I love to hear them grouse about who has the best relationship with Jalen Brunson. (Ben Stiller [has said](#) he's envious of Mariska Hargitay's bond with the captain and MVP. Delicious!) I'm happy that the team has won the—I googled this—Eastern Conference finals, but really, I'm happy for Stiller and Spike Lee and Tracy Morgan and, believe it or not, [Sarah Jessica Parker](#). Most of all, though, I'm happy for Timothée Chalamet.

Chalamet has been having a bit of a rough time lately. For the second year in a row, he failed to win the Best Actor Oscar he set his sights on. His campaign, for his role in the film *Marty Supreme*, is [widely understood to have backfired](#), leaving some with the impression that he's cocky and ungrateful, as well as [an enemy to the ballet and opera communities](#). One of his biggest fans, the artist formerly known as Club Chalamet, even announced that she was [taking a step back](#). It's impossible to know if any of this really got to him; he was still living a charmed life, with a hit movie and a hot Kardashian by his side, so how bad were things, really? But it was also easy to imagine him laid low by so publicly gunning for a prize and coming up short.

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During last year's basketball season, Chalamet was a fixture at Knicks games. His appearances reinforced a narrative he had been pushing during his promotion of, and subsequent Oscar campaign for, the Bob Dylan biopic *A Complete Unknown*: that he was, despite his artsy-fartsy bona fides, a bro who knows ball. No one could question his credentials as a fan, because the internet

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teemed with evidence that he'd been a die-hard supporter since childhood, and his court-side gesticulations proved his emotional investment. Both he and the Knicks failed to go all the way that year, to the Oscar podium or the NBA finals, but they put in respectable performances, ensuring that everyone would consider them contenders the following year.

For the Knicks, it worked, and they've already gotten further than they did in 2025. I wondered, though, if Chalamet would be quite so visible at MSG following this year's more devastating Oscar loss. Whether or not that ever crossed his mind, he seems to have decided not to let it get in the way of his Knicks fandom, and he's been just as much of a regular in 2026. Despite all the talk of overexposure during Oscar season, these public appearances don't seem to have brought on more criticism, much less widespread booing at MSG. In fact, they seem to be doing the opposite. In retrospect, it was probably a little naive of me to think that Knicks fans might turn on Chalamet after his comments about ballet and opera; as I said, this is not my world.

Showing up night after night to Knicks games—including skipping attending the Met Gala when it conflicted with the playoffs—has been a great move for Chalamet, allowing him to build back some of the goodwill he lost during the awards race. Last week, he may have further ingratiated himself with fickle former fans by showing up at a game with a new haircut and without the regrettable mustache he had been sporting for a while. Suddenly, he looked like his adorable self again. Maybe his signature curls wouldn't be far behind the newly bare lip? “Uhhh fuck ballet,” [one writer tweeted](#), satirizing but also summarizing public sentiment. Is the American public really so shallow that we were mad at Chalamet for being annoying and too in our faces a few months ago, but now that he's looking good again and his team is winning, all is forgiven? Obviously, of course we are.

Would Chalamet have had a better shot at the Oscars if they came after basketball season? He is learning the lesson that many spring-sport big men on campus who failed to secure homecoming king titles in the fall have learned before him: Timing is everything. My real fear, however, is that this year's Knicks season will end up echoing Chalamet's 2026 Oscar run: They lose in a final against the San Antonio Spurs or Oklahoma City Thunder, massive fan backlash follows, dark days. But if we've learned anything, it's that if the worst happens, Brunson can always change his hair and get a fresh start. It may not be this year, it may not be next year, but neither Chalamet or the Knicks are giving up anytime soon.

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